

The Storm

The Storm

*A Collection of the Most Remarkable
Casualties and Disasters which happen'd in the
Late Dreadful Tempest, both by Sea and Land*

DANIEL DEFOE

NORTH PASS PRESS

2026

*The Storm; or, a Collection of the Most Remarkable Casualties and Disasters
which happen'd in the Late Dreadful Tempest, both by Sea and Land*

First Edition

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Contents

A Note On This Edition	1
The Preface	5
Advertisement	13
Chapter One	15
Chapter Two	24
Chapter Three	32
Chapter Four	46
Chapter Five	62
The Storm – An Essay	197
Layman's Sermon Upon the Late Storm	209

A Note On This Edition

This edition of *The Storm* is based on the 1704 first edition, originally printed in London by George Sawbridge and sold by J. Nutt. While the text is reproduced complete and unabridged, we have generally preserved the original spelling and rationalized the original italics and capitalization where necessary for ease of reading. In a small number of cases, spelling has been modernized where the original form could obscure the intended meaning—for example, where the absence of an apostrophe makes it unclear whether a word is plural or possessive. These changes have been kept to a minimum and do not otherwise alter the language of the text. Punctuation follows the primary source faithfully, with corrections limited to clear typographical errors.

The storm which forms the subject of this book struck Great Britain on the night of November 26, 1703. For several days, violent winds swept across the country, destroying houses, uprooting trees, wrecking ships, and taking thousands of lives. The devastation was so extensive that it quickly became a national event—not merely a catastrophe witnessed by those who endured it, but an event whose effects were felt throughout the kingdom.

Daniel Defoe was determined that the experience should not be forgotten. In the days following the storm, Defoe issued a public appeal for firsthand accounts. The advertisement preceding this preface is transcribed from the original notice published in *The London Gazette* on December 2, 1703. In it, Defoe called upon those who had witnessed the storm to communicate what they had seen, heard, and suffered. Their accounts would become the raw material for the work that followed.

The inclusion of this advertisement is therefore more than a bibliographical curiosity. It preserves the beginning of Defoe's investigation and reveals something essential about the nature of *The Storm*. Defoe was not content merely to relate what he had personally experienced or to repeat the reports already circulating in London. He sought testimony. He gathered accounts from across England, compared the experiences of different communities, and attempted to preserve the memory of the disaster through the voices of those who had actually lived through it.

The circumstances surrounding Defoe's engagement with the storm were themselves remarkable. In "The Storm, An Essay," included in this volume, he writes from what he cryptically calls the 'limbus of the law,' declaring that he had never told his readers where he was. The poem thus offers a brief glimpse into the precarious circumstances in which its author found himself. Yet, amid his personal uncertainty, Defoe turned outward, gathering and preserving the experiences of others. One of Defoe's most remarkable journalistic projects thus emerged during one of the most difficult periods of his life.

The result is a work remarkable for both its immediacy and its method. *The Storm* occupies an unusual place between journalism and history. It records ships lost at sea and houses destroyed on land, but it also records the bewilderment, fear, courage, and grief of ordinary people confronted with a force beyond their control. Defoe's great achievement was to recognize that these individual experiences, easily scattered and forgotten, together formed a national history worth preserving.

For Defoe, however, the storm was not merely a natural event. The disaster prompted widespread reflection upon providence, mortality, human frailty, and the moral condition of the nation. The destruction of property and the loss of life raised questions that could not be answered by statistics alone. What did such an event mean? How should it be remembered? And what ought those who survived to learn from it?

Two companion works included in this volume help to answer those questions. "The Storm, An Essay" and "The Layman's

Sermon Upon the Late Storm” broaden the record beyond the immediate narrative of destruction. Together, they reveal the storm as it was interpreted by contemporaries: as a natural catastrophe, a national crisis, a political event, and, above all, a subject of serious moral and spiritual reflection. Defoe’s own poem is particularly revealing, combining his interpretation of the storm as an act of providence with reflections upon the political condition of the nation and the personal circumstances of its author.

More than three centuries later, the immediacy of Defoe’s subject has not entirely disappeared. Storms still destroy homes, ships are still lost at sea, and communities still struggle to make sense of sudden catastrophe. What has changed is the speed with which such events are recorded and forgotten. Defoe worked without modern communications, yet he understood something that remains remarkably relevant: when disaster strikes, the testimony of ordinary people is precious. Once the witnesses are gone, what was seen and suffered can easily vanish with them.

This edition seeks to preserve that testimony in the form in which Defoe first presented it. Along with the complete text, we have restored the advertisement that initiated his investigation and included the companion works that help place *The Storm* within its original cultural and spiritual context.

We trust that these pages will serve not merely as a record of a night long remembered, but as a reminder of the value of preserving history while its witnesses can still speak.

North Pass Press
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The Preface

Preaching of sermons is speaking to a few of mankind: printing of books is talking to the whole world. The parson prescribes himself, and addresses to the particular auditory with the appellation of 'My brethren'; but he that prints a book, ought to preface it with a *Noverint universi*—know all men by these presents.

The proper inference drawn from this remarkable observation, is, that tho' he that preaches from the pulpit ought to be careful of his words, that nothing pass from him but with an especial sanction of truth; yet he that prints and publishes to all the world, has a tenfold obligation.

The sermon is a sound of words spoken to the ear, and prepar'd only for present meditation, and extends no farther than the strength of memory can convey it; a book printed is a record, remaining in every man's possession, always ready to renew its acquaintance with his memory, and always ready to be produc'd as an authority or voucher to any reports he makes out of it, and conveys its contents for ages to come, to the eternity of mortal time, when the author is forgotten in his grave.

If a sermon be ill grounded, if the preacher imposes upon us, he trespasses on a few; but if a book printed obtrudes a falsehood, if a man tells a lye in print, he abuses mankind, and imposes upon the whole world, he causes our children to tell lyes after us, and their children after them, to the end of the world.

This observation I thought good to make by way of preface, to let the world know, that when I go about a work in which I must tell a great many stories, which may in their own nature seem incredible, and in which I must expect a great part of mankind will question the sincerity of the relator; I did not do it without a

particular sence upon me of the proper duty of an historian, and the abundant duty laid on him to be very wary what he conveys to posterity.

I cannot be so ignorant of my own intentions, as not to know, that in many cases I shall act the divine, and draw necessary practical inferences from the extraordinary remarkables of this book, and some digressions which I hope may not be altogether useless in this case.

And while I pretend to a thing so solemn, I cannot but premise I should stand convicted of a double imposture, to forge a story, and then preach repentance to the reader from a crime greater than that I would have him repent of: endeavouring by a lye to correct the reader's vices, and sin against truth to bring the reader off from sinning against sence.

Upon this score, tho' the undertaking be very difficult among such an infinite variety of circumstances, to keep exactly within the bounds of truth; yet I have this positive assurance with me, that in all the subsequent relation, if the least mistake happen, it shall not be mine.

If I judge right, 'tis the duty of an historian to set every thing in its own light, and to convey matter of fact upon its legitimate authority, and no other: I mean thus (for I would be as explicit as I can), that where a story is vouch'd to him with sufficient authority, he ought to give the world the special testimonial of its proper voucher, or else he is not just to the story: and where it comes without such sufficient authority, he ought to say so; otherwise he is not just to himself. In the first case he injures the history, by leaving it doubtful where it might be confirm'd past all manner of question; in the last he injures his own reputation, by taking upon himself the risque, in case it proves a mistake, of having the world charge him with a forgery.

And indeed, I cannot but own it is just, that if I tell a story in print for a truth which proves otherwise, unless I, at the same time, give proper caution to the reader, by owning the uncertainty of my knowledge in the matter of fact, 'tis I impose upon the world; my relator is innocent, and the lye is my own.

I make all these preliminary observations, partly to inform the reader, that I have not undertaken this work without the serious consideration of what I owe to truth, and to posterity; nor without a sense of the extraordinary variety and novelty of the relation.

I am sensible, that the want of this caution is the foundation of that great misfortune we have in matters of ancient history; in which the impudence, the ribaldry, the empty flourishes, the little regard to truth, and the fondness of telling a strange story, has dwindled a great many valuable pieces of ancient history into meer romance.

How are the lives of some of our most famous men, nay the actions of whole ages, drowned in fable? Not that there wanted pen-men to write, but that their writings were continually mixt with such rhodomontades¹ of the authors that posterity rejected them as fabulous.

From hence it comes to pass that matters of fact are handed down to posterity with so little certainty, that nothing is to be depended upon; from hence the uncertain account of things and actions in the remoter ages of the world, the confounding the genealogies as well as achievements of Belus, Nimrod, and Nimrus, and their successors, the histories and originals of Saturn, Jupiter, and the rest of the celestial rabble, who mankind would have been ashamed to have called *gods*, had they had the true account of their dissolute, exorbitant, and inhuman lives.

From men we may descend to action: and this prodigious looseness of the pen has confounded history and fable from the beginning of both. Thus the great flood in Deucalion's time is made to pass for the Universal Deluge: the ingenuity of Dedalus, who by a clue of thread got out of the Egyptian maze, which was thought impossible, is grown into a fable of making himself a pair of wings, and flying through the air:—the great drought and violent heat of summer, thought to be the time when the Great Famine was in Samaria, fabl'd by the poets and historians into Phaeton borrowing the chariot of the sun, and giving the horses

¹Rhodomontade: boastful, arrogant, or vainglorious speech or behaviour

their heads, they run so near the earth as burnt up all the nearest parts, and scorch'd the inhabitants, so that they have been black in those parts ever since.

These, and such like ridiculous stuff, have been the effects of the pageantry of historians in former ages: and I might descend nearer home, to the legends of fabulous history which have swallow'd up the actions of our ancient predecessors, King Arthur, the gyant Gogmagog, and the Britain, the stories of St. George and the Dragon, Guy Earl of Warwick, Bevis of Southampton, and the like.

I'll account for better conduct in the ensuing history: and tho' some things here related shall have equal wonder due to them, posterity shall not have equal occasion to distrust the verity of the relation.

I confess here is room for abundance of romance, because the subject may be safer extended than in any other case, no story being capable to be crowded with such circumstances, but Infinite Power, which is all along concern'd with us in every relation, is suppos'd capable of making true.

Yet we shall nowhere so trespass upon fact, as to oblige Infinite Power to the shewing more miracles than it intended.

It must be allow'd, that when nature was put into so much confusion, and the surface of the earth and sea felt such extraordinary a disorder, innumerable accidents would fall out that, till the like occasion happen, may never more be seen, and unless a like occasion had happen'd, could never before be heard of: wherefore the particular circumstances being so wonderful, serve but to remember posterity of the more wonderful extreme, which was the immediate cause.

The uses and application made from this terrible doctrine, I leave to the men of the pulpit; only take the freedom to observe, that when Heaven it self lays down the doctrine, all men are summon'd to make applications by themselves.

The main inference I shall pretend to make or at least venture the exposing to publick view, in this case, is, the strong evidence God has been pleas'd to give in this terrible manner to his

own being, which mankind began more than ever to affront and despise: and I cannot but have so much charity for the worst of my fellow-creatures, that I believe no man was so hard'n'd against the sence of his Maker, but he felt some shocks of his wicked confidence from the convulsions of nature at this time.

I cannot believe any man so rooted in atheistical opinions, as not to find some cause to doubt whether he was not in the wrong, and a little to apprehend the possibility of a Supreme Being, when he felt the terrible blasts of this tempest. I cannot doubt but the atheist's hard'n'd soul trembl'd a little as well as his house, and he felt some nature asking him some little questions; as these — *Am not I mistaken? Certainly there is some such thing as a God — What can all this be? What is the matter in the world?*

Certainly atheism is one of the most irrational principles in the world; there is something incongruous in it with the test of human policy, because there is a risque in the mistake one way, and none another. If the Christian is mistaken, and it should at last appear that there is no future state, God or Devil, reward or punishment, where is the harm of it? All he has lost is, that he has practiced a few needless mortifications, and took the pains to live a little more like a man than he would have done. But if the atheist is mistaken, he has brought all the Powers, whose being he deny'd, upon his back, has provok'd the Infinite in the highest manner, and must at last sink under the anger of him whose nature he has always disown'd.

I would recommend this thought to any man to consider of, one way he can lose nothing, the other way be undone. Certainly a wise man would never run such an unequal risque: a man cannot answer it to common arguments, the law of numbers, and the rules of proportion are against him. No gamester will set at such a main; no man will lay such a wager, where he may lose, but cannot win.

There is another unhappy misfortune in the mistake too, that it can never be discover'd till 'tis too late to remedy. He that resolves to die an atheist, shuts the door against being convinc'd in time.

*If it should so fall out, as who can tell,
But that there is a God, a Heaven, and Hell,*

*Mankind had best consider well for fear,
'Tshould be too late when his mistakes appear.*

I should not pretend to set up for an instructor in this case, were not the inference so exceeding just; who can but preach where there is such a text? When God himself speaks his own power, he expects we should draw just inferences from it, both for our selves and our friends.

If one man, in an hundred years, shall arrive at a conviction of the being of his Maker, 'tis very worth my while to write it, and to bear the character of an impertinent fellow from all the rest.

I thought to make some apology for the meanness of stile, and the method, which may be a little unusual, of printing letters from the country in their own stile.

For the last I only leave this short reason with the reader, the desire I had to keep close to the truth, and hand my relation with the true authorities from whence I receiv'd it, together with some justice to the gentlemen concern'd, who, especially in cases of deliverances, are willing to record the testimonial of the mercies they received, and to set their hands to the humble acknowledgment. The plainness and honesty of the story will plead for the meanness of the stile in many of the letters, and the reader cannot want eyes to see what sort of people some of them come from.

Others speak for themselves, and being writ by men of letters, as well as men of principles, I have not arrogance enough to attempt a correction either of the sense or stile; and if I had gone about it, should have injur'd both author and reader.

These come dressed in their own words because I ought not, and those because I could not mend 'em. I am persuaded, they are all dress'd in the desirable, though unfashionable, garb of truth, and I doubt not but posterity will read them with pleasure.

The gentlemen, who have taken the pains to collect and transmit the particular relations here made publick, I hope will have their end answer'd in this essay, conveying hereby to the ages to come the memory of the dreadfulest and most universal judgment that ever Almighty Power thought fit to bring upon this part of the world.

And as this was the true native and original design of the first undertaking, abstracted from any part of the printer's advantage, the editor and undertakers of this work, having their ends entirely answer'd, hereby give their humble thanks to all those gentlemen who have so far approv'd the sincerity of their design as to contribute their trouble, and help forward by their just observations, the otherwise very difficult undertaking.

If posterity will but make the desired improvement both of the collector's pains, as well as the several gentlemen's care in furnishing the particulars, I dare say they will all acknowledge their end fully answer'd, and none more readily than

The Age's Humble Servant.

Advertisement

London Gazette — December 2, 1703

To preserve the remembrance of the late dreadful tempest, an exact and faithful collection is preparing of the most remarkable disasters which happened on that occasion, with the places where, and persons concerned, whether at sea or on shore. For the perfecting so good a work, 'tis humbly recommended by the author to all gentlemen of the clergy, or others, who have made any observations of this calamity, that they would transmit as distinct an account as possible, of what they have observ'd, to the undertakers, directed to John Nutt near Stationers' Hall, London. All gentlemen that are pleased to send any such accounts, are desired to write no particulars but what they are well satisfy'd to be true, and to set their names to the observations they send, which the undertakers of this work promise shall be faithfully recorded, and the favour publickly acknowledged.

Chapter One

Of the natural causes and original of winds

Though a system of exhalation, dilation, and extension, things which the ancients founded the doctrine of winds upon, be not my direct business; yet it cannot but be needful to the present design to note, that the difference in the opinions of the ancients, about the nature and original of winds, is a leading step to one assertion which I have advanc'd in all that I have said with relation to winds, *viz.* That there seems to be more of God in the whole appearance, than in any other part of operating nature.

Nor do I think I need explain my self very far in this notion: I allow the high Original of nature to be the Great Author of all her actings, and by the strict rein of his Providence, is the continual and exact guide of her executive power; but still 'tis plain that in some of the principal parts of nature she is naked to our eye. Things appear both in their causes and consequences, demonstration gives its assistance, and finishes our further enquiries: for we never enquire after God in those works of nature which depending upon the course of things are plain and demonstrative; but where we find nature defective in her discovery, where we see effects but cannot reach their causes; there it is most just, and nature herself seems to direct us to it, to end the rational enquiry, and reserve it into speculation: nature plainly refers us beyond herself, to the mighty hand of Infinite Power, the Author of Nature, and Original of all causes.

²Arcana: (Latin *arcanum*) Deep secrets or hidden mysteries; the internal, inscrutable workings of a system—in this case, the Divine government of the natural world.

Among these arcana² of the sovereign oeconomy, the winds are laid as far back as any. Those ancient men of genius who rifled nature by the torch-light of reason even to her very nudities, have been run a-ground in this unknown channel; the wind has blown out the candle of reason, and left them all in the dark.

Aristotle, in his problems, Sect. 23, calls the wind, "*Aeris Impulsum*."³ Seneca says, "*Ventus est aer fluens*."⁴ The Stoics held it, "*Motum aut fluxionem aeris*."⁵ Mr. Hobs,⁶ "Air moved in a direct or undulating motion." Fournier, "*Le vent est un mouvement agitation de l'air causé par des exhalations et vapeurs*."⁷ The moderns, "A hot and dry exhalation repulsed by antiperistasis;"⁸ Descartes defines it, "*Venti nihil sunt nisi motus, etc.*"⁹ *Dilati vapores*, and various other opinions are very judiciously collected by the learned Mr. Bohun in his treatise of the *Origin and Properties of Wind*, and concludes, "That no one hypothesis, how comprehensive soever, has yet been able to resolve all the incident phenomena of winds."¹⁰

This is what I quote them for, and this is all my argument demands; the deepest search into the region of cause and consequence, has found out just enough to leave the wisest philosopher in the dark, to bewilder his head, and drown his understanding. You raise a storm in nature by the very inquiry; and at last, to be rid of you, she confesses the truth and tells you, "It is not in me, you must go home and ask my father."

Whether then it be the motion of air, and what that air is, *which as yet is undefin'd*, whether it is a dilation, a previous contrac-

³Trans. A striking of the air.

⁴Trans. Wind is moving air.

⁵Trans. The motion or flux of air.

⁶Thomas Hobbes.

⁷Trans. Wind is a movement or agitation of the air caused by exhalations and vapors.

⁸Antiperistasis: An obsolete physical theory suggesting that a quality (such as heat or cold) intensifies when surrounded by its opposite; here used to explain the compressed motion of air as a cause of wind.

⁹Trans. Winds are nothing but motion, etc.

¹⁰Bohun, *Of Winds*, p. 7, 9

tion, and then violent extension as in gun-powder, whether the motion is direct, circular, or oblique, whether it be an exhalation repuls'd by the Middle Region,¹¹ and the antiperistasis of that part of the heavens which is set as a wall of brass to bind up the atmosphere, and keep it within its proper compass for the functions of respiration condensing and rarifying, without which nature would be all in confusion; whatever are their efficient causes,¹² 'tis not much to the immediate design.

'Tis apparent, that God Almighty, whom the philosophers care as little as possible to have any thing to do with, seems to have reserv'd this, as one of those secrets in nature which should more directly guide them to himself.

Not but that a philosopher may be a Christian, and some of the best of the latter have been the best of the former, as Vossius, Mr. Boyle, Sir Walter Raleigh, Lord Verulam,¹³ Dr. Harvey, and others; and I wish I could say Mr. Hobbs, for 'twas pity there should lie any just exceptions to the piety of a man, who had so few to his general knowledge, and an exalted spirit in philosophy.

When therefore I say the philosophers do not care to concern God himself in the search after natural knowledge; I mean, as it concerns natural knowledge, *meerly as such*; for 'tis a natural cause they seek, from a general maxim, that all nature has its cause within it self: 'tis true, 'tis the darkest part of the search, to trace the chain backward; to begin at the consequence, and from thence *hunt counter*, as we may call it, to find out the cause: 'twould be much easier if we could begin at the cause, and trace it to all its consequences.

I make no question, the search would be equally to the advantage of science, and the improvement of the world; for without doubt there are some consequences of known causes which are not

¹¹The middle layer of the atmosphere, once believed to be the source of all meteorological phenomena and a cold boundary that contained the Earth's air.

¹²A philosophical term referring to the agent or force that directly produces an effect.

¹³Sir Francis Bacon.

yet discover'd, and I am as ready to believe there are yet in nature some *terra incognita*¹⁴ both as to cause and consequence too.

In this search after causes, the philosopher, tho' he may at the same time be a very good Christian, cares not at all to meddle with his Maker: the reason is plain; we may at any time resolve all things into Infinite Power, and we do allow that the finger of the Infinite is the first mighty cause of nature her self: but the treasury of immediate cause is generally committed to nature; and if at any time we are driven to look beyond her, 'tis because we are out of the way: 'tis not because it is not in her, but because we cannot find it.

Two men met in the middle of a great wood; one was searching for a plant which grew in the wood, the other had lost himself in the wood, and wanted to get out: the latter rejoyc'd when thro' the trees he saw the open country; but the other man's business was not to get out, but to find what he look'd for: yet this man no more undervalued the pleasantness of the champion country¹⁵ than the other.

Thus in nature, the philosopher's business is not to look through nature, and come to the vast open field of Infinite Power; his business is in the wood; there grows the plant he looks for; and 'tis there he must find it. Philosophy's a-ground if it is forc'd to any farther enquiry. The Christian begins just where the philosopher ends; and when the enquirer turns his eyes up to heaven, farewell philosopher; 'tis a sign he can make nothing of it here.

David was a good man, the Scripture gives him that testimony; but I am of the opinion, he was a better king than a scholar, more a saint than a philosopher: and it seems very proper to judge that David was upon the search of natural causes, and found himself puzzled as to the enquiry, when he finishes the enquiry

¹⁴Terra incognita: Latin for "unknown land." Historically used by cartographers to label unexplored regions on a map; here used to describe the yet-to-be-discovered laws of nature.

¹⁵Champion country: From the French "champagne"; refers to open, flat, or unenclosed land, providing a direct contrast to the "wood" of nature.